

Committee: Security Council

Topic: Navigating Catastrophic Regional Displacement: Sovereign Borders, Ethics of Forced Migration, and the Mandate for Global Resettlement

Head Chair: Hollansa Cardoso

Co-Chair: Natalia Schärer Milošević



Introduction

Millions of people are being forced to leave their homes because of wars, violence, climate disasters, and collapsing governments. This is creating huge pressure on countries that take them in and raising big questions about borders, fairness, and who should help. The Security Council has to figure out how to deal with these massive movements without ignoring countries' rights to control their own borders, while still protecting people who have nowhere safe to go.

Key Words

Forced Migration - When people have no real choice and have to leave home because of war, persecution, disasters, or climate problems. This includes refugees and people stuck inside their own country.

Non-Refoulement - The basic rule that says you can't send any person back to a place where they will be killed or seriously hurt because of who they are or what they believe.

Resettlement - Moving refugees from the country they first escaped to over to a new country that agrees to take them in permanently. One of the main long term solutions.

Sovereign Borders - A country's right to decide who comes in and who doesn't.

IDP - Someone forced to flee their home due to conflict, violence, or disasters, but who remains inside their own country's borders. Unlike refugees, IDPs do not cross an international border.

General Overview

As of the end of 2024, around 120 million people worldwide had been forced out from their homes. About 40 million needed international protection and the rest were IDPs. The low to middle income countries host 76% of the refugees, mostly because they border the countries of origin despite having the fewest resources. These countries already have a lack of money therefore the refugees put a strain on their resources, social dynamics, and even security.

The biggest causes of displacement today are the war in Sudan (the largest displacement crisis), the Syrian situation (although some people have started returning after the political changes in late 2024-25), the war in Ukraine, the Rohingya crisis between Myanmar and Bangladesh, and climate related movements.

The main international rules for refugees come from the 1951 Convention Relating to the Status of Refugees and the 1967 Protocol. They define what a refugee is and they reinforce non-refoulement. These are supported by the 2016 New York Declaration and the 2018 Global Compact on Refugees (GCR), which try to make countries share the responsibility more fairly, expand the resettlement options, and support the countries that are hosting everyone. The UNHCR estimates that about 2.5 million refugees will need resettlement in 2026, mainly Afghans, Syrians, South Sudanese, Sudanese, Rohingya, and Congolese. But the actual resettlement numbers are far below that number because funding often falls short during UNHCR operations.

Previously, the Security Council has mostly talked about the peace and security side of mass displacement like violence spilling over borders, risks of radicalisation, border control and getting human aid through instead of the admin side of asylum systems. Resolutions usually call for support to host countries, protection of civilians and rejection of forced displacement as a war crime.. Debates usually get into the ethics surrounding refugees. Usual topics include whether or not states should lawfully restrict irregular arrivals, the conditions under which returns are truly voluntary, the responsibility of the origin states, and the equitable distribution of resettlement places among wealthier nations.

Climate change makes everything worse by pushing more people to move (both internally and across borders) in more fragile regions. The Guiding Principles on Internal Displacement and the Secretary-General's Action Agenda on Internal Displacement are guidelines for IDPs. The challenge is to create solutions that respect borders while also dealing with the root causes and creating more safe, legal ways for people to move.

Major Parties Involved

UNHCR (United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees) - The lead UN agency in charge of protecting refugees and assisting in finding long term solutions.

Major Host Countries (Türkiye, Islamic Republic of Iran, Pakistan, Uganda, Ethiopia, Chad, Bangladesh, Colombia, Germany) - They take in the largest numbers of refugees and advocate for more international support and sharing of burden.

Countries of Origin (Sudan, Syria, Afghanistan, Myanmar, Ukraine, South Sudan, Democratic Republic of Congo) - They are the sources of the largest flows of displacement. Their political stability, governance and willingness to facilitate safe returns are central to durable solutions.

Resettlement/Donor States (USA, Canada, Australia, European Union member states) - They provide the majority of resettlement places and humanitarian funding; face domestic political pressures over borders and migration while being called upon to expand third country solutions.

Timeline of Relevant Events

Year	Event
1951	Adoption of the Convention Relating to the Status of Refugees
1967	Adoption of the Protocol Relating to the Status of Refugees, removing geographic and temporal limits
2011	Start of the Syrian civil war, triggering one of the largest refugee crises of the 21st century
2016	New York Declaration for Refugees and Migrants adopted by the UN General Assembly
2017	Mass displacement of Rohingya from Myanmar to Bangladesh
2018	Global Compact on Refugees affirmed by the UN General Assembly
2022	Full-scale Russian invasion of Ukraine generates millions of refugees and IDPs
2023	Outbreak of conflict in Sudan between SAF and RSF, creating the world's largest displacement crisis
2023–2024	Escalation of hostilities in Gaza producing mass internal displacement

2024–2025	Political changes in Syria enabling significant voluntary returns of refugees and IDPs
2025	UNHCR projects 2.5 million resettlement needs for 2026; global forced displacement remains above 120 million with mixed trends of new displacements and returns
2025–2026	Continued high levels of internal displacement in Sudan, DRC, and other conflict zones; ongoing Rohingya protracted situation

Relevant Documents

<https://www.unhcr.org/uk/about-unhcr/overview/1951-refugee-convention>

1951 Convention Relating to the Status of Refugees and 1967 Protocol – Foundational instruments defining the term “refugee,” establishing non-refoulement, and setting minimum standards of treatment.

<https://www.unhcr.org/about-unhcr/overview/global-compact-refugees>

Non-binding framework for more equitable responsibility-sharing, expanded resettlement and complementary pathways, support for host communities, and addressing root causes.

Possible Solutions

1. *Actually expand resettlement and other legal pathways* - More countries need to take refugees permanently, and there should be more options such as work visas, study visas, and family reunification plans to prevent people from having to take dangerous journeys.
2. *Give host countries long term support instead of just emergency aid.* Multi-year money, development help and including refugees in local schools and health systems so host communities don't feel completely overwhelmed.
3. *Ensure the fairness and efficiency of asylum systems while controlling borders.* Help countries process claims adequately and keep people safe as their cases are being investigated instead of leaving them in limbo or pushing them back.

Works Cited

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